

Swimming

VIRDHAWAL KHADE, 16

Kolhapur-born Khade gave up his Xth board exams to take a shot at qualifying for Beijing—and will be the youngest Indian in the Games pool. He has become the boy who changed all benchmarks for Indian swimming.

"I want to break my best times in Beijing."

"but it's not the way to producing world champions. It's a short-term strategy." Sumariwala, working president of the Athletics Federation of India (AFI), believes corporates also need to be involved at the grassroots. "There are 10,000 kids competing at inter-district level. We can identify the best among them and then we need corporates to bring in the best coaches and expertise to look after them."

Any disgruntlement from federations at these cash-rich newcomers riding into town flinging money about should be tempered with the acknowledgement that India's sports structures have hardly churned out champ after champ. They need desperate reinvention of the kind the AFI may try by marketing their city marathons and contemplating the appointment of a CEO.

Initiatives like the MCT and the OGG offer more than money or solutions to athletes' short-term needs. They offer India's sporting elite more options, greater opportunities—to extend skill, to expand the mind. They give our finest sportsmen and women guide-maps to the roads less travelled by their predecessors. Malhotra says, "We want to prove that if we do things differently, we can win." Champia says, "I would have never reached this level without help from the MCT. We get top-class equipment and coaching. I've learnt more than archery, I've



Archery

MANGAL SINGH CHAMPIA, 24

An early MCT's signing, the Jharkhand archer led India to gold at the 2007 Asian Championships. Bronze in the individual event was his ticket to Beijing where he is regarded as a medal contender.

"I would never have reached this level without the MCT."

learnt concentration, composure." Nehwal says, "With a big sponsorship behind me I can play as many events as I want." A month before Beijing, she played the world's best on the Asian circuit and broke into the world's top 20 for the first time. In her Olympic year, Popat had played seven or eight events. Today she follows Nehwal's career and laughs over the phone, "We don't have to be the underdogs all the time."

Khade sits in coach Nihar Amin's small office in Bangalore, a dolphin-esque dive away from a pool filled with the high-pitched chattering and shrieking of children at swim camp. At his first

day near a pool, Khade says, he was just like them, terrified of being sucked into the blue depths. Today, he is regarded as the boy who has changed the benchmarks for Indian swimming. He's not finished yet and he wants to be the first Indian to win an Olympic swimming medal. It won't come in Beijing but who knows what could happen in London?

It is an audacious idea. A swimming medal from a land of vegetarian landlubbers with largely defunct aqua-lungs.... He cannot be serious. Politeness requires that he is asked instead if that dream is possible, if his goal is realistic? Khade pauses, but only to inhale. "Yeah," he exhales. **with Elora Sen**